THESIS PROPOSAL

General Information: Article (35 & 36) of granting master's degree regulations 2022/2023.
The student cannot submit the thesis (Proposal) before obtaining approval for the request to appoint a supervisor for his/her thesis.
The student shall submit the research project subject of his/her thesis before the end of the second semester of joining the program.
*The student **who transferred to the thesis track shall submit to the department concerned the research project subject of the thesis before the end of the consecutive semester of his/her transfer to the thesis track**.*
*The student must present the proposal to the department GS committee in an **open session**.*

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THESIS PROPOSAL
An Exploration of the Psychosocial Experiences of Older Syrian Refugees in the context of economic empowerment
استكشاف التجارب النفسية لدى للاجئين السوريين من كبار السن في سياق التمكين الاقتصادي

Abstract:
The present research proposal investigates the way economic engagement (formal, informal, home-based) and structural exclusion from livelihood programs influence identity, dignity, and psychosocial well-being among older Syrian refugees (50–65) residing in protracted displacement in Jordan. Refugees of advanced age frequently encounter a diminution of social role and status, a phenomenon that has the potential to exacerbate feelings of anxiety, depressed mood, and a sense of diminished purpose. However, their experiences are often characterized by a perception of vulnerability rather than agency, contribution, or future orientation. To address this gap, the study employs a qualitative narrative inquiry design, utilizing in-depth semi-structured interviews to capture the lived experiences of two distinct groups:
(a) individuals who have utilized economic support or opportunities and
(b) those who have endeavored to participate but have been excluded due to criteria related to age, health, or program requirements.
The proposal integrates clinical social work concepts (loss of role, meaning-making, dignity restoration) within a Person-in-Environment (PIE) lens to analyze how structural barriers interact with subjective well-being and a sense of community efficacy (perceived capacity to contribute and matter socially). Furthermore, the study goes beyond the assessment of current functioning to explore participants' future aspirations and imagined roles in the context of post-conflict social cohesion and reconstruction in Syria. The findings will generate evidence that is grounded in culture and will inform interventions that are trauma-informed, age-inclusive, and sensitive to identity. These interventions will be implemented to address livelihood and psychosocial needs.

Objective(s):

- To explore real-life stories of older Syrian refugees (50–65) about working or not having the chance to work in Jordan.
- Learning how working or being excluded changes their identity and their sense of self-respect (dignity) after they were forced to leave their home.
- To check the link between having an income (or not) and their psychological well-being (like feeling anxious, depressed, or isolated) and their feeling of being useful to the community.
- To explore the concept of hope in relation to the future and the jobs/roles they imagine for themselves in rebuilding social connections in Syria after the conflict.
- To develop evidence-based suggestions for policymakers to protect the rights of older refugees.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Primary Research Question

How do older Syrian refugees in Jordan perceive the role of economic engagement in influencing psychosocial well-being?

Sub-Questions

1. How does economic engagement (formal/informal) affected on older Syrian refugee ?
2. How do experiences of exclusion affect self-reported anxiety, depressive feelings, isolation, and meaning?

Background:
This study is based on academic literature from clinical social work, refugee studies, and psychosocial theory. It brings together six important areas that **will guide** research questions and theoretical approach.

Jordan has hosted Syrian refugees for over a decade. While many projects support refugee youth and families, one group remains mostly invisible in research and programming: older refugees aged 50–65. In this study, "older refugees" are defined as those aged **50–65**. This age range follows humanitarian practice that treats individuals aged 50+ as older adults in displacement settings due to early onset of chronic illness, functional decline, and psychosocial vulnerability in contexts of protracted crisis (UNHCR, 2011; HelpAge International, 2014; Global Protection Cluster, 2016). International research on other refugee groups supports the need for a flexible, context-sensitive age threshold: for example, a recent study with Congolese refugees in the United States included participants aged **55–67** (mean age = 65.7), reflecting early ageing-related vulnerability among displaced populations (Owino, 2024). In the Arab region, cultural expectations position men and women in their fifties as providers and family leaders (Al-Krenawi & Graham, 2000), while humanitarian and labor market logics tend to exclude those above 50 from livelihood opportunities (Lupieri, 2022; Hachem et al., 2022; Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022). This makes the **50–65** group a critical, yet under-examined, population whose experiences of identity, dignity, and psychosocial well-being in relation to economic life require focused study.

These individuals are often left out of livelihood programs because they are seen as "less investable" or "less productive" than younger people (Lupieri, 2022). Humanitarian actors label older refugees as "vulnerable," yet deprioritize them because of perceived low economic return, creating ageist "deservingness" hierarchies that exclude them from essential services and opportunities (Lupieri, 2022). But at the same time, Arab cultural traditions expect them to be providers, respected leaders, and role models in their families and communities (Al-Krenawi & Graham, 2000). This mismatch—between being excluded by programs and expected to lead by culture—creates a strong identity crisis. It affects how older refugees see themselves, how others treat them, and how they cope mentally and socially. In humanitarian reports, this age group is rarely given focused attention. For example, HelpAge International (2014) says that older people are often "invisible" in emergency aid, even though they face chronic illnesses, depression, and isolation. Recent studies confirm this pattern: Hachem et al. (2022) found that older Syrian refugees in Lebanon are systematically overlooked in humanitarian responses, leading to increased income insecurity, dependency, and worsening food insecurity and untreated non-communicable diseases. Similarly, Abi Chahine and Kienzler (2022) documented pervasive ageism at agency, family, and individual levels that reduces participation and access to care, increasing isolation and poor mental and physical health among older Syrian refugees. The consequences of this exclusion are profound. Al Omari et al. (2024) provided empirical evidence that exclusion from programs and cash transfers forces older refugees to make impossible trade-offs choosing between rent, food, and medication—that harm their dignity, health, and self-worth. Older refugees face barriers to employment, increased dependency on younger relatives, and a loss of autonomy that erodes their sense of value (Hachem et al., 2022). Nashwan et al. (2022) found medium overall quality of life scores among older Syrian refugees in Jordan, with variation by education and gender, indicating impacts across health, social relationships, independence, and finances. In my own work with economic support programs in Jordan, I noticed something powerful. When older refugees had a chance to work—even small home-based activities—they felt better about themselves. They became more hopeful, more social, and regained a sense of

dignity. These are not just personal impressions; they are signals supported by emerging research. Sidhva et al. (2021) showed that middle-aged Syrian women contribute paid and unpaid work within households, often operating small home-based businesses that sustain families, and that these productive activities preserve self-worth and family status despite exclusion from formal livelihoods. This study aims to explore these experiences in a respectful, evidence-based way, focusing specifically on how older Syrian refugees (aged 50–65) experience identity, dignity, and psychosocial well-being when excluded from economic life.

Literature review:

1. Older Refugees and Structural Exclusion

Studies confirm that older refugees face many problems (multiple layers of exclusion): in health care, getting documents, legal rights, and especially in job programs (economic programming) (HelpAge International, 2014). Recent evidence shows this exclusion is not just by chance (not accidental) but is part of the system (structural). This is because aid rules and market thinking see older refugees as lower 'value for money' (Lupieri, 2022). Lupieri's (2022) ethnographic study in Jordan found that humanitarian workers do not give high priority (deprioritize) to older refugees for health and job help, because they are seen as less productive. This creates a system that judges them by age (ageist hierarchy of 'deservingness') and pushes them away (systematically marginalizes this group).

This exclusion based on age causes big problems (serious consequences). Hachem et al. (2022) found that crises increased money problems (income insecurity) and relying on others (dependency) among older Syrian refugees in Lebanon. This made food problems worse and left chronic diseases (non-communicable diseases) without treatment. Al Omari et al. (2024) counted (quantified) these unmet needs in a study (mixed-methods study) of 461 older Syrian refugees in Lebanon. They found bad shelter, hard choices (competing priorities) like rent versus food/medication, high cost of medicine, and no programs made for their age. Their findings give proof (empirical evidence) that exclusion from programs and cash help forces hard choices (tradeoffs) that hurt dignity, health, and self-worth.

One study in Jordan found older Syrians feel very anxious and feel forgotten by NGOs and family (Bridi et al., 2023). This shows that age-based exclusion is not only a money problem, it is structural and psychosocial (mental/social). Abi Chahine and Kienzler (2022) found ageism everywhere (pervasive ageism): in agencies, families, and people. This reduces participation and access to care, which increases isolation and leads to poor mental and physical health. They ask for complete (holistic), age-inclusive services that respect older refugees' dignity and social roles.

Karlsson and Jönsson (2020) summarize global research on older refugees. They note that older refugees face losing their work identity, social support, chronic health problems, and money problems (financial instability). They argue for age-inclusive, rights-based social work that keeps dignity and participation safe. This evidence shows clearly that older refugees are systematically excluded. This exclusion hurts (undermines) their independence (autonomy), dignity, and social roles.

2. Displacement and Trauma: Mental Health Impacts

Long-term displacement can lead to depression, loneliness, and a deep loss of role. Research by Al-Smadi et al. (2022) shows a strong link between having no money (economic insecurity) and feeling stressed (psychological distress) among Syrian refugees in Jordan. Maconick et al. (2020) did qualitative research with Syrian patients who had chronic sicknesses (NCD patients) in Jordan. They found that patients talk about suffering in many ways (intertwined physical, mental, and social suffering). Social factors like poverty and isolation change mental health and make it harder to seek help. This shows how social suffering hurts (undermines) dignity and psychosocial well-being among older patients with chronic illness.

Bridi et al. (2023) studied older Syrian refugees (aged 55 and above) in Jordan and their ideas about memory problems (dementia and cognitive aging). Participants linked high stress, low income, poor health, and traumatic history to more risk of dementia. They also noted problems with getting jobs and care because of policy rules. This highlights stigma, the fear of becoming a burden to family, and exclusion that threatens their identity, family roles, and psychosocial well-being. This research shows that older refugees connect high stress and trauma with memory problems, and that stigma affects asking for help and their identity as elders.

Trauma-informed practice (TIP) reminds us that poverty and exclusion is a type of damage (form of harm), not just the background (George, 2010). In this study, I see economic life as part of psychosocial assessment. The evidence shows that displacement, exclusion, and poverty create a cycle of mental health challenges that are deeply connected to identity and dignity. Moayerian et al. (2023) looked at Syrian refugees' access to medical and social support. They found that being excluded (marginalization), limited services, and relying on employers' kindness (goodwill) affects refugees' independence and dignity. This shows the difficult choice (tradeoffs) between having a job (marginal labor inclusion) and dignity that changes older men's identity and access to care.

3. Productive Aging and Psychological Immunity

New studies show that older people can be productive and resilient (strong), not just vulnerable. The idea of Productive Aging (Lum, 2013) says that contributions can be small work, volunteering, advising (mentoring), and family support. Research confirms this makes well-being and identity better (Ma et al., 2021). For Syrian refugees, this can rebuild psychological immunity—their inner ability to stay strong despite hardship.

Recent proof supports this idea. Sidhva et al. (2021) did interviews with middle-aged Syrian women in Jordan. They found that these women do paid and unpaid work at home, often running small home businesses that support their families. Cultural authority changes during displacement, but this productive work helps them keep their self-worth and family status despite being excluded from formal jobs. This shows that even informal work at home can restore economic power (agency) and dignity among older adults, especially women.

Zuntz (2021) studied Syrian livelihoods and money sent home (remittances) in Jordan. She found that family networks before the war still shape how they find work. But displacement changed (reshaped) family duties and old-age support. This shows how broken work networks affect older adults' money security, identity, and social roles. This research highlights that older refugees used to rely on money from outside (transnational remittances) and seasonal migration for old-age support, but displacement and closed borders have broken these systems, making their money problems and role loss worse.

The evidence suggests that programs that allow home-based micro-enterprises, cash plus social support, and recognizing unpaid care work can restore economic power and dignity (Sidhva et al., 2021; Zuntz, 2021). Nashwan et al. (2022) found that quality of life among older Syrian refugees in Jordan is different by education and gender. Less money and less independence mean lower quality of life. This shows the link between lower quality of life, loss of power, economic exclusion, and changes in social status among older adults.

4. Narrative Therapy and Identity Repair

When people lose their roles, they often need to "rewrite" their life story. Narrative Therapy (White, 1997) helps people remember who they are, not only the trauma. For example, a father who lost his job can find his value again as a community helper or mentor. This study will look at how older refugees tell their own stories of loss, dignity, and contribution.

Recent research supports using narrative methods for rebuilding identity. Bunn et al. (2023) did narrative interviews with 31 Syrian refugees in Jordan. They said there are four parts of ambiguous loss: safety, social identities, connection to place, and the future they imagine. Their process model shows a cycle of losing and making "home" again in displacement, linking loss of place and social identity to threats to dignity and the need for narrative reconstruction. This research shows that displacement breaks identity and that narrative methods can help refugees talk about and rebuild their sense of self.

Issari et al. (2021) used narrative inquiry to explore the life stories of six Syrian refugees in Greece. They found that narrative methods put the focus on refugees' own story of life before the war, the break (rupture), the journey, and their hopes. This shows how narrative restores power (agency) and meaning. Saltsman and Majidi (2021) talk about participatory narrative

methods, being heard (audibility), and the politics of visibility in refugee research. They give methodological advice for narrative methods that help rebuild identity and keep dignity safe in research with older refugees.

Muhanna-Matar (2020) looked at changing men's roles (masculinities), aging, and physical problems (embodied impairments) among displaced Syrian men with disability and chronic illness in Jordan. This research connects aging bodies and disability with identity crisis and loss of dignity among older men. This work shows that narrative methods are not only research tools but also therapeutic ways (interventions) that can help older refugees restore power, stop being labeled only as "vulnerable", and support dignity by focusing on their strengths and social roles.

5. Family, Social Capital, and Social Entrepreneurship

Older refugees often live in close family systems, and their identity is connected to how much they contribute. Studies on refugee business (entrepreneurship) show that family support and small work can create strength (resilience) (Zehra & Usmani, 2023). Even informal work at home can help rebuild social links and self-worth.

Recent research gives proof of these things. Sidhva et al. (2021) found that middle-aged Syrian women's home-based enterprises support families and keep their authority and self-esteem safe even with exclusion from formal programs. Zuntz (2021) showed that family networks before the war shaped work strategies and old-age support, and that displacement changed these family duties. This shows how broken work networks affect older adults' money security, identity, and social roles.

Bridi et al. (2023) noted that older refugees fear becoming a burden to family, and that stigma affects their identity as elders. This makes clear how important family roles and social capital are in shaping older refugees' feeling of value and well-being. Moayerian et al. (2023) found that Syrian refugees rely on employers' kindness (goodwill) and social networks to get services. This shows the difficult choice (tradeoffs) between having a job (marginal labor inclusion) and dignity that changes older men's identity and access to care.

The evidence suggests that family support, social capital, and informal economic activities is very important (critical) for older refugees' psychosocial well-being and identity. Programs that recognize unpaid care work, support home-based businesses, and make social networks stronger can help restore dignity and self-worth (Sidhva et al., 2021; Zuntz, 2021).

6. The Gap: No Qualitative Research Focused on Age 50–65

But, despite all these findings, no study has focused exactly on how exclusion from work (economic life) based on age affects the dignity and identity of older Syrian refugees aged 50–65. Most studies look at youth, children, or the elderly over 65. The studies reviewed above give important information about older refugees' experiences, but they often put older adults in a big group (e.g., 55+, 60+) or focus on only some people (e.g., women, men with disabilities).

Many studies ask for collecting data separated by age (age-disaggregated data) and putting older adults in needs assessments all the time. This is to fix their invisibility and make programs that fit their age (age-tailored programs) (Hachem et al., 2022; Al Omari et al., 2024; Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022). Evidence supports putting chronic sickness care (non-communicable disease care) with mental health support (MHPSS) and age-friendly services. This is to help with physical and mental/social needs at the same time (Maconick et al., 2020; Bridi et al., 2023).

Using storytelling (Participatory storytelling and narrative inquiry) is recommended to understand identity changes, make interventions that keep dignity safe, and make programs that fit the culture (Saltsman & Majidi, 2021; Issari et al., 2021). Policies based on rights, inclusion for all ages, and trauma-informed social work are necessary to fight ageism, keep identity safe, and support older refugees' participation in community life (Karlsson & Jönsson, 2020; Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022).

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This research builds on ecological social work, trauma-informed practice, and solidarity-based approaches to figure out how identity, dignity, and psychosocial well-being get shaped—and sometimes damaged—by age-based exclusion among older Syrian refugees in Jordan. These perspectives collectively show that being excluded from livelihood programs is actually a form of harm that messes up dignity and identity. The framework also incorporates the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), using them as a global justice lens to back up older adults' rights to inclusion, participation, and dignity.

Ecological Social Work and the Person-in-Environment (PIE) Model

The Person-in-Environment (PIE) model frames distress as coming from interactions between people and their complex environments (Karlsson & Jönsson, 2020). This study uses PIE to understand how structural exclusion—like program criteria that favor younger refugees, labor market barriers, health issues, and ageist policies—erodes identity, dignity, and well-being for older Syrian refugees. (Karlsson and Jönsson 2020) argue that the marginalization of older refugees is caused by the overlap of policy exclusions, ageism, and poor service design; they say social work must restore rights and livelihood access to maintain dignity. Bunn et al. (2023) developed a model of ambiguous loss, showing that losing economic roles undermines identity and dignity, which helps clarify how exclusion from livelihood programs makes these harms worse. Bridi et al. (2023) showed how economic insecurity and strict institutional policies trickle down (cascade) into psychosocial stressors and difficulty accessing services. Xiong et al. (2021) pointed out that family centrality and community support are key resources for adjustment and well-being, suggesting collective ways to cope. The ecological and PIE lenses help interpret structural exclusion as a psychosocial process that starts with policy but spreads (ripples) through family systems, community networks, and individual identity, ultimately affecting mental health and self-worth.

Trauma-Informed Practice: Reframing Economic Exclusion as Harm

Trauma-informed practice (TIP) changes how we think about economic exclusion by treating poverty and marginalization as forms of harm that threaten safety, autonomy, trust, and dignity (George, 2010). Based on my time in economic support programs, I've seen firsthand how being excluded from meaningful work impacts older refugees' sense of self and hope. TIP recognizes that exclusion from work and social roles can be traumatizing, especially for people who have already faced displacement, loss, and violence. Moayerian et al. (2023) found that marginal employment undermines safety and trust, arguing that dignity is tied to autonomy—which is gone when livelihood options are excluded. This means livelihood programs shouldn't just be evaluated on money outcomes but also on whether they restore safety, choice, and control. (Maconick et al. 2020) used Kleinman's social suffering concept to show how structural and economic pressures mix with mental distress, leading to narratives of despair that reflect threats to dignity and identity. Papadopoulos (2022) introduced Adversity Grid to move away from simple trauma narratives and focus back on agency and strengths, supporting livelihood efforts that use prior skills and roles to restore dignity and identity. This study sees economic exclusion as a form of structural violence—something that hurts economic security, psychological safety, social identity, and dignity (Karlsson & Jönsson, 2020; Maconick et al., 2020; Moayerian et al., 2023).

Solidarity-Based Economy and Social Work

While mainstream humanitarian aid often relies on market logic and efficiency, solidarity-based economy approaches prioritize mutual aid, collective well-being, and non-market ways of creating value (Sidhva et al., 2021; Zuntz, 2021). Solidarity economy principles question the idea that economic participation must be formal employment, instead recognizing the value of unpaid care work, home-based activities, kinship networks, and community contributions. Lupieri (2022) showed how neoliberal thinking treats older refugees as lower "value for money," causing systematic exclusion that eats away at dignity and social worth. Zuntz (2021) mapped pre-war kinship and remittance networks that still structure refugee household economies, demonstrating that livelihoods cross borders (transnational) and that local program exclusion hurts older refugees' financial security and their identity as providers and elders. Sidhva et al. (2021) documented informal, home-based economic activities and critiqued "self-reliance" models that don't match cultural realities, noting that formal programs often exclude older adults. For older Syrian refugees, this just means recognizing their important roles as mentors, caregivers, household managers, and cultural leaders, even if they're not in the formal job market (Sidhva et al., 2021; Zuntz, 2021).

Community Efficacy: Restoring Dignity, Meaning, and Social Agency

This study brings in community efficacy as a concept: basically, participants' feeling that they can contribute, matter, and be socially effective despite displacement constraints. Community efficacy is treated as a psychosocial outcome shaped by both economic opportunities and social recognition. It’s bigger than individual self-efficacy, including the collective and relational aspects of agency—the feeling that your actions actually have meaning and impact. Xiong et al. (2021) showed that family and community provide a sense of belonging that buffers psychological harm and offers informal livelihood support. Abi Chahine and Kienzler (2022) defined ageism as something at multiple levels that reduces participation and social worth, creating a link between program exclusion and the denial of dignified economic participation. Hachem et al. (2022) linked multiple crises (compound crises) to older refugees' income insecurity, social exclusion, and psychological problems like guilt and losing agency. Nashwan and Alzouabi (2023) showed how changes in economic roles reconfigure self-worth and claims to agency. When older refugees can’t participate economically, their community efficacy is threatened. But when meaningful opportunities are available—whether through paid work, volunteering, mentoring, or household production—community efficacy, dignity, purpose, and social agency can be restored (Xiong et al., 2021; Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022; Hachem et al., 2022).

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs): A Rights-Based Lens for Inclusion and Justice

The framework uses the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)—especially poverty (SDG 1), health (SDG 3), decent work (SDG 8), and reduced inequalities (SDG 10)—as a global justice lens that supports older adults' rights to inclusion and dignity. SDG 1 (No Poverty) calls for social protection for everyone; exclusion just makes poverty continue. SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-Being) emphasizes mental health; economic exclusion is a psychosocial issue, affecting mental health, identity, and dignity (Maconick et al., 2020; Bridi et al., 2023). SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth) promotes inclusive growth; age-based exclusion is the opposite of this. SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities) calls for the inclusion of everyone; ageism is a form of inequality (Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022; Lupieri, 2022). Karlsson and Jönsson (2020) view poverty and unemployment as rights being taken away. The SDGs give this study a strong policy and advocacy framework, grounding arguments for inclusion in global commitments.

Synthesis: An Integrated Framework

Together, these lenses create a combined framework for understanding how age-based exclusion affects older Syrian refugees' well-being:

- Ecological and PIE perspectives interpret structural exclusion as a psychosocial process that flows from policy down to the family, community, and individual (Karlsson & Jönsson, 2020; Bunn et al., 2023; Bridi et al., 2023; Xiong et al., 2021).
- Trauma-informed practice redefines economic exclusion as harm that needs structural solutions (George, 2010; Moayerian et al., 2023; Maconick et al., 2020; Papadopoulos, 2022).
- Solidarity-based economy approaches critique market logics and value non-market contributions, offering ways to restore dignity and agency (Lupieri, 2022; Zuntz, 2021; Sidhva et al., 2021).
- Community efficacy offers a way to see how economic participation/exclusion shapes the perceived ability of older refugees to contribute and matter (Xiong et al., 2021; Abi Chahine & Kienzler, 2022; Hachem et al., 2022; Nashwan & Alzouabi, 2023).
- Relevant SDGs (1, 3, 8, 10) provide a rights-based perspective for advocating for age-inclusive programs (Karlsson & Jönsson, 2020).

This framework guides the research questions and interview approach. It positions the study as an inquiry into the psychosocial consequences of structural exclusion, with important takeaways for social work, humanitarian aid, and policy advocacy. By focusing on dignity, identity, and community efficacy, the framework puts the experiences of older Syrian refugees at the center, treating them as active participants whose exclusion is a harm that needs to be fixed with rights-based, trauma-informed, and solidarity-focused interventions.

Methodology:

Study Design

This research uses a qualitative narrative inquiry approach. This method is suitable for exploring how older Syrian refugees in Jordan understand their experiences of economic exclusion, identity, and dignity. Narrative inquiry lets participants share personal stories and meanings in their own words. In-depth semi-structured interviews will be used for flexibility while focusing on the main topics.

The study will fill this gap by using narrative interviews to ask older Syrian refugees (aged 50–65) directly:

- "What happens to your identity when you are excluded because of your age?"
- "What makes you feel valuable again?"
- "What do you imagine for your role in the future of Syria?"

By focusing on this specific age group and using narrative methods, this research wants to make visible the experiences of older refugees who are systematically excluded. Also, it wants to explore how working, family roles, and cultural expectations change their identity, dignity, and psychosocial well-being.

Context of the Study

The study will be done in both urban areas and refugee camp settings in Jordan. The researcher will contact local NGOs and community networks to find participants. These locations show different living conditions and access to services.

Participants and Sampling

Purposive and snowball sampling will be used to find participants who meet the criteria. This helps reach older refugees who might otherwise go unnoticed. The inclusion criteria are:

- Being a Syrian refugee living in Jordan.
- Aged 50 to 65.
- Both Male and female.
- Having recent experience (past 3 years) with at least one of these:
    - Getting economic support (cash aid, grants).
    - Trying to join a livelihood program but being excluded due to age or health.
    - Doing informal or home-based economic work because formal access is missing.

We plan for 15–20 interviews, or until thematic saturation (no new themes appear).

Data Collection

The interviews will be in Arabic by the researcher (a native speaker familiar with Syrian culture). This helps build trust and ensures accurate talk. All interviews start with explaining the study and getting informed consent. Audio recordings will only be taken with consent; otherwise, detailed field notes will be written.

An interview guide will structure the talk but allow flexibility. It will explore:

- Life roles and identity before displacement.
- Experiences of exclusion and coping strategies.

- Feelings of dignity and social recognition.
- Mental and social well-being.
- Economic activity and hopes for the future.
- The researcher will apply to the IRB committee at GJU to obtain approval to conduct the study.

Data Analysis

Thematic analysis will be used to analyze the data. The steps are:

1. Transcribe interviews in Arabic.
2. Translate transcripts into English, making sure meaning and cultural context are kept.
3. Code the data and find patterns.
4. Group codes into themes related to identity, dignity, economic life, and community efficacy.
5. Interpret these themes against the research questions and framework.

The researcher will also keep reflective notes throughout to reduce bias and ensure participants' voices are respected and the researcher will be using reflexive memos to track own assumptions and emotional responses during analysis.

Outcomes:

This research should give us the following important results:

- Narrative Insight: A more straightforward understanding of how economic participation—or being shut out of it—affects older Syrian refugees' feelings about their identity, dignity, and sense of purpose.
- Mental Health Link: Proof showing how losing social and economic roles leads to distress (like depression or isolation), and how unofficial work or family help could make things better.
- Practical Recommendations: Real, usable ideas for making livelihood and mental health programs that are fair to older people (age-inclusive) and sensitive to past trauma (trauma-informed), helping to keep their dignity intact and encouraging them to join in.
- Policy Contribution: Solid facts that demonstrate how existing program rules might be leaving out older adults, and ideas on how to fix those rules using principles of dignity and inclusion.

Timetable:

Phase 1 (1 month): Literature consolidation, tool finalization, IRB approval, partnerships.
Phase 2 (1 months): Recruitment + 15–20 interviews + transcription.
Phase 3 (1 month): Thematic analysis + reflexive memos + interpretation.
Phase 4 (1 month): Thesis writing, supervisor review, revisions, submission.

Originality and contribution:
This study's originality comes from treating age-related exclusion from livelihood programming as a core psychosocial mechanism rather than a side issue, and from integrating:
• Clinical social work concepts (identity rupture, meaning, dignity) with
• PIE structural analysis and
• Future-orientation/social cohesion narratives.
It offers actionable contributions to humanitarian programming, clinical practice, and policy discussions on age-inclusive livelihood opportunities.

POSITIONALITY AND BIAS STATEMENT:

I acknowledge that I approach this topic as an insider researcher: a Syrian refugee living in Jordan, which supports trust, language nuance, and cultural understanding. I also bring professional experience in economic empowerment programming: I served as Economic Justice Unit Coordinator within Ruwwad's "From Innovation to Creation" project, supporting business development and career counselling, coordination, documentation, and partner follow-up.
. This experience gives me practical knowledge of how programs work and where exclusion happens.
To manage risks of over-identification or leading questions, I will use:

1. Reflexive journaling (bracketing assumptions),
2. Peer debriefing with my supervisor,
3. Consistent use of open-ended narrative prompts,
4. An ethical "stop and support" procedure if distress emerges.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

• Informed consent: voluntary participation; refusal has no effect on services.
• Confidentiality: anonymization; encrypted storage; removal of identifiers.
• Do-no-harm: trauma-informed interviewing; participant control over what to share; right to pause/stop.
• Risk and referral: clear referral pathway for severe distress.
• Institutional approval: IRB/ethics approval before recruitment.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

Though there appears to be a considerable gap in the studies related to refugees as well as the practice of humanitarian intervention, specifically in respect to senior refugees of Syria, most of the research tends to be confined to economic factors such as income and employment. However, there appears to be little emphasis on what occurs in regard to one's identity or feeling of belonging as a consequence of being excluded from economic participation simply due to advancing age.
In general, the importance of this study can be clarified into three principal areas:
Clinical Social Work Practice:
When the exclusion of livelihood is considered within the context of psychosocial evaluation, the social workers will have the ability to better comprehend the implications that are associated with the exclusion of individuals on the aspects of mental well-being and the identity of the family members. I have noted that the aspect related to the exclusion of individuals from the

participation of livelihood is a form of rejection of the purpose of life for the individuals within the refugees that I handle.

Humanitarian Programming:

Program designers and deliverers working in the field tend to make assumptions that younger refugees make up the "productive" sector of society and that older people contribute relatively little. This paper seeks to correct that approach by placing the emphasis on what life is like for older refugees. The evidence suggests that what needs to change is that programs need to include all ages. Instead of treating older refugees as dependents, it is possible for the humanitarians to view them as contributors.

For Older Refugees:

Perhaps most significantly, the work here affords a voice to a population that has all too frequently been relegated to the background. Through the experiences of the mature refugees' struggles, challenges, and hopes, the work here brings a voice and a lived experience that can more closely inform the discussions about practice and policy that seem to shape their world. Lastly, the research ties in with the global goals, including the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs 1, 3, 8, and 10), in affirming the importance of not leaving anyone behind in relation to age, dignity, and psychosocial well-being, in addition to economic issues.

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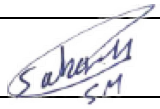
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SUPERVISOR APPROVAL			
The project described above is original and relevant: ☒ Yes ☐No			
Name:	Dr.Nada Eltaiba		
Affiliation:	German Jordanian University		
Signature:		Date:	11/1/2026

PROPOSAL DEFENSE COMMITTEE:		
Dr.Bader AlMadi	Signature:	11/1/2026
Dr.Tamara Al Rawwad	Signature:	11/1/2026
Dr.Sahar AlMakhamreh	Signature: 	11/1/2026
Committee member Name	Signature:	
Defense Date:	Click or tap to enter a date	
Defense Place:	Click or tap here to enter text	

DEPARTMENT GS COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS	
Clarity and Coherence of the Research Proposal • Clear articulation of research objectives, hypotheses, or research questions. • Logical flow and structure of the presentation, including background, methodology, and expected outcomes. • Use of appropriate language, visuals, and communication tools to convey ideas effectively.	☐ Exceeds expectations ☐ Meets expectations ☐ Needs improvement

Significance and Originality of the Research • The research addresses a significant gap or problem in the field. • Demonstrates originality and innovation in approach, hypothesis, or methodology. • Clear potential contribution to knowledge, industry, or societal impact.	☐ Exceeds expectations ☐ Meets expectations ☐ Needs improvement
Quality of the Research Methodology • Feasibility and appropriateness of the proposed research methods to achieve objectives. • Clear explanation of experimental design, data collection, and analysis methods. • Identification and mitigation of potential challenges or limitations in the methodology.	☐ Exceeds expectations ☐ Meets expectations ☐ Needs improvement
Understanding of the Field and Literature • Comprehensive review and understanding of relevant literature. • Proper contextualization of the research within the field's current state of knowledge. • Ability to address questions related to theoretical or technical aspects of the research.	☐ Exceeds expectations ☐ Meets expectations ☐ Needs improvement
Presentation and Defense Skills • Professionalism and confidence during the presentation. • Effective use of time and engagement with the audience. • Ability to address questions and defend the proposal with logical, evidence-based responses.	☐ Exceeds expectations ☐ Meets expectations ☐ Needs improvement
Committee Recommendation	☐ Pass ☐ Revise and resubmit ☐ Reject

OFFICIAL APPROVALS			
Head of Department GS Committee:			☐ Approve ☐ Decline
Comments: Comments			
Decision no.: Text			
Signature:		Date:	Date
Head of School GS Committee:			☐ Approve ☐ Decline
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